

In a grave near Munich, Germany, a whole range of surgeon's equipment was found which promptly caused the grave (#7) to be labelled by the archealogists "the warrior surgeon's grave." The surgical instruments included a retractor, probes and a trephining saw and a cylindrical skull drill.

As Dr. Simon James commented: "In medicine, as in so many other areas, the Celts stand favourable comparison with the classical world."

We know from the skulls of several skeletons that the Celts often did neurosurgery and were adept at the trephining operation, making circular cuts into the skull in order to relieve pressure in the case of head injuries or, it has been suggested, psychological disorders. Several times we find skulls which have been trephined as many as three times.

In 1935 the best example of a skull was found that showed the success of ancient trephining operations. A fisherman brought it up in his net near sussex.

The skull has two large round holes cut into it over the brain pan.. It dates from the 1st or 2nd century BC.

The remarkable thing about this skull is that the ancient Celtic surgeons had cut into it on two separate occasions; The healing of the bone around both holes indicated that the patient survived both operations but eventually died of sepsis some weeks after the second.

Similar skulls have been discovered on the continent where the patient has survived the infections and the shock of such operations.. Some skulls, such as one found in Austria, show three attempts at trephining. Two holes were completed but the third was not, and there were no signs of healing. Obviously, this patient died on the operating table, so to speak.

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The first native, Celtic record of trephining is found in the account of a battle in 637 AD. An Irish cheifton named Cennfaelad<sup>cenn fael ad</sup> had his skull fractured by a sword blow. He was taken to the medical school <sup>Tuam Breacan</sup> Tuam Breacan and had the injured part of his skull and a portion of his brain removed.

On his recovery, it was said that his wits were as sharp as ever and he became a great scholar and author of a book "Primer of Poets, a work still existing in copied form.

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These physicians carried a stethoscope, a horn called a <sup>gip ne</sup> gipne or gibne, which means Physicians horn. We know this from early Irish sources.

In the ancient Celtic world, water was the source of health as well as of life. The link with water, the divine waters from heaven from which the Celtic peoples, according to their philosophy, had their origin, was all pervasive..

therefore we find that rivers and springs were the focus of ritual practices designed to ensure well-being. Like their fellow Indo-Europeans, the Hindus, the Celts regarded water with veneration and they had their sacred rivers.

They bathed in them and offered votive gifts to the deities of the springs and rivers; these offerings included wooden models of themselves or the affected part of their limbs, together with all manner of treasures.

Most Celtic river names are identified with goddesses.. One of the most popular was <sup>Se quana</sup> SEQUANA, the goddess of the Seine. She seems to have been particularly prayed to and given offerings in connection with various diseases of the organs. Some of the votive offerings are wooden and stone images of limbs, organs, heads and complete bodies. Many images showing blindness or swollen eyes.

The images were offered to her with coins and items of jewellery. This does not mean, of course, that the people placed their faith in the offering to the goddess alone but that, as well as placing

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themselves in the hands of their physicians, a prayer to their gods and goddesses would not be a bad idea. In fact, there was little difference in their attitude to our attitude today.

○ The offering of images of limbs and organs was by no means confined to the Celtic world. The practice occurred among the Greeks, and even in medieval times in certain Christian communities. But certainly it was widespread in the Celtic world, and many such images are to be found at the healing shrines in Britain.

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We find in the Irish medical tracts that baths were frequently prescribed for healing. A hot air bath was used in Ireland as a cure for, among other things, rheumatism. It was called Tigh <sup>clg na al. uis</sup> 'n alluis, or "sweating house". One such ancient structure survives in Donegal Bay and others described.

The 'sweating house' was a stone cabin around 2 meters long. A turf fire was kindled inside and the place heated like an oven. The fire was removed. The patient wrapped in a blanket, went inside and <sup>clg na al. uis</sup> t down on a bench. The door was closed up. The patient remained until a profuse perspiration developed and then, on leaving, they plunged in cold water before being rubbed dry.

The patient was encouraged to meditate to achieve a state of peace. This process has been found in many cultures in the world, even among the Native American peoples, and has the same religious connotations as in the Celtic world.

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Only in Irish mythology do we have a god of medicine clearly defined. This was Dain Cecht who, with his daughter Airmid, guarded a healing spring which restored the dead and wounded to life.

After Nauda, the leader of the Tuatha De Danaan, lost his hand in battle, <sup>Dan keet</sup> Dian Cecht supplied him with a silver hand. However, the blemish excluded <sup>Na u da</sup> Nauda from kingship and another man became king.

However, <sup>Mee ach Dan Ceets</sup> Miach, Dian Cecht's son, proved himself a better physician by providing Nuada with a new hand of flesh and blood and

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allowed him to regain his kingdom.

Unfortunately, Dian <sup>Dán</sup> Cecht <sup>Keet</sup> grew increasingly jealous of his son and eventually killed him. <sup>Air mid</sup> Airmid gathered the herbs that grew on her brother's grave and laid them out on her cloak in order of their various healing properties. <sup>Dán</sup> Dian, still jealous, overturned the cloak and hopelessly confused the herbs so that no human would learn the secret of immortality by their use.

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<sup>Pliny</sup> Pliny was the first classical writer to give an account of Celtic medical knowledge, and he pointed out that it was the Druids who possessed these skills.

As the Druids were the Celtic intellectual caste, it was natural that the professional role of healer would be one of those assumed by them. It has been asserted that the medical knowledge of the Druids was what gave them power in Celtic society, altho this is a matter for debate.

Pliny in the first century AD, also stressed the Druidic physicians were possessed of "magical lore", something he was particularly interested in when writing his 'Naturalis Historia'.

When records begin in insular Celtic, the druid physicians are regarded as skilled in the prescription of herbs as well as in surgery. among the operations they performed were Caesarean sections, neurosurgery and straightforward amputations.

We can find an entire medical corps accompanying various armies and it is no coincidence that the name is a compound of *faith*, a seer, and *liaig*, a physician..

We know from later European sources that the Irish physicians were renowned for their skill in medical botany, including the production of herbal sleeping potions. Of course, the use of poisons was also known..

It is Pliny who links the Druids with mistletoe, saying: "They believe that mistletoe given in drink will impart fertility to any animal that is barren, and that it is an antidote to all poisons.

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Today it is believed that mistletoe is beneficial to sufferers of insomnia, high blood pressure and certain malignant tumors.

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## BREHON LAWS AND MEDICINE

It is known that the first hospice in Europe for the sick and needy, the first hospital, was established by Christians in the fourth century. However, such institutions had been established by the Indo-Europeans of India. in the 3rd century BC. The emperor of India, Asoka (c273-232) sickened by war and the struggle for power, turned to Buddhism and professional non-violence, establishing the first hospitals in India for the ailing poor.

what was overlooked in Europe is that Irish sources refer to the establishment of the first hospital in Ireland by the semi-legendary queen <sup>Má chár Mong Ruadh</sup> Macha Mong Ruadh (d. 377BC).

She is said to have established a hospital called <sup>Brō in Bērg</sup> Broin Bherg (house of sorrow) at <sup>E main má chár</sup> Emain Macha. It remained in use in <sup>Ná Ván</sup> Navan until its destruction in 22 AD.

Legendary or not, we do know that such hospitals were in existence by the time of the Christian period in Ireland, some for sick people with general ailments and others serving specialist needs, such as leper hospitals.

The Brehon laws indicate the existence of an advanced and sophisticated medical system, for they ordered that hospitals be made available in all tribal areas. This implies a long tradition of medical practice..

The Irish language contains the world's largest collection of medical texts in any one language prior to 1800. There are translations of works credited to Hippocrates, Galen, and many others, including Muslim doctors as well as many other European medical scholars in addition to the native books of learning. The surviving texts date from between the 14th and 16th centuries. The <sup>oldest</sup> ~~best~~ surviving medical textbook in Ireland dates from 1352.



Under the Brehon laws the provision of sick maintainance, including the price of curative treatment, attendance allowance and nourishing <sup>Food</sup> ~~ed~~, was made available for everyone who needed it.

Expenses for the treatment of wounded people, those injured unlawfully, were paid out of the fines which the perpetrators of the deed had to pay. The LAW OF TORTS says that "full sick maintenance must be paid to a worker injured for the sake of unnecessary profit. . ."

The Brehon laws make it clear that only qualified physicians could treat the sick and there were severe penalties if unqualified physicians were found practising..

The qualified physicians were responsible for the treatment of their patient and if, thru negligence or ignorance, they caused a patient's condition to worsen, they had to pay compensation.

Each qualified physician undertook by law to maintain four medical students and train them. Every so often the physician was allowed, under law, to take a sabbatical and devote himself to catching up on <sup>New</sup> ~~the~~ knowledge and techniques.

Each territory had to maintain a hospita.l. The law is exact on the conditions under which it was to be built and maintained. It should have four doors, be placed by a stream of running water, and be maintained free of charge or taxation by the local assembly.l

The local physician and his students were in charge. There was a full time caretaker or hospital manager who was employed to keep away stray dogs, mentally sick people, who had their own institutions, and anyone liable to cause the sick or injured distress.

<sup>no</sup> The Irish laws relating to medicine and the fragmentary evidence from the continent demonstrate that ancient Celtic society was concerned with protecting its sick and ailing poor at a time when tending the ill was not a priority in neighboring socities.

The economic backbone of Celtic society, which was <sup>essentially</sup> essentially rural like most ancient societies, was in its farms. Celtic farmers were part of a continuum which archeologists can trace back to the Bronze age.

Archaeology disproves the popular notion of the Celts being an itinerant people, constantly traveling Europe in great hordes, attacking and looting as they went. Both agricultural and pastoral farming were practised and indeed became highly sophisticated as the Celts combined their technology with other rural knowledge and skills.

Their technology enabled them to produce the first <sup>100</sup> harvesting machine; the Celtic Plow, fitted with a mobile coulter, <sup>which was</sup> (a sharp knife). It was greatly superior to the Roman swing plough of the same period.

The plough was, of course, the very basis of agriculture. The earliest picture of a Celtic plough is found in a rock carving near Milan, where the Celts had settled from the start of the Hallstatt period. These date to about the 7th century BC. They also developed iron shares while their neighbors continued to use wooden ones. They could penetrate regions previously impossible to plough and cultivate.

Among the British Celts, the iron share and coulter plus the practice of crop rotation <sup>200</sup> and manuring, seemed to mark a major change in intensive farming before the end of the second century BC.

They evolved the first harvesting machine, the MESSOR, later called Vallus by the Romans. According to Pliny, this was a "big box, the edges armed with teeth and supported by two wheels, which moved thru the <sup>grain</sup> ~~corn~~ field pushed by an ox rather, The grain was then uprooted by the teeth and fell into the box."

The introduction of iron obviously helped farmers in that sickles, scythes, spades, forks, axes and billhooks became more powerful and sophisticated. Cutting tools were attached to their handles by means of sharp spike on the tool going into a wooden handle or haft.

The Celts grew a large variety of crops, depending, of course, on the area they inhabited. Wheat, spelt, millet Barley, rye and oats, <sup>beans</sup> peas and lentils as well as many fruits and berries. The Celts of Southern Gaul and the Po valley of Italy began to cultivate vineyards and produce their own wines.

Where water power was available, they developed the water mill and were in use in Ireland by the 3rd century AD. For preservation, the Celts were great salt producers and salting was their chosen method of preservation, especially of meats.

Pits were used for storage and a large number have been found. this puzzled the archeologists for awhile but experiments showed that if the pit was sealed, the grain in contact with the damp walls would germinate, using available oxygen and releasing carbon dioxide. This would cause the rest of the grain to go into a form of suspended animation so that it lasted in perfect condition for many months.

As well as planting, the Celts practised pastoral farming. They kept <sup>sheep</sup> cattle and pigs, but their varieties were very different from modern day domestic farm animals.

The bones of sheep discovered by archaeologists show that the breeds kept by the Celtic farmers were small and goat-like, rather like the modern <sup>Soay</sup> sheep from St. Kilda, in Scotland. The wool of this breed is short, coarse and usually dark.

They were exploited for their wool and milk rather than meat. The production of woollen goods from Britain was well known in Caesar's time for such items were part of a thriving export business from Britain to Rome.

Cattle became an indicator of wealth and "cattle raids" were a common occurrence in Ireland and Scotland. Early Irish units of exchange were based on sed, which was the value of one milk cow.

Because of the importance of cattle in Celtic society, bulls played a major role in Celtic culture. Images of bulls begin to appear in the <sup>Hallstatt</sup> culture and they are frequently connected with sacrificial



rituals, one of which is mentioned by Pliny. The bull ritual has already been mentioned in regard to kingship. The significance of bulls can be seen in insular Celtic mythology, particularly the Irish saga of the *Ten Bo Cuailgne*.  
Tĕn bō Cool nē

Pigs were the second most common domesticated animals in the Celtic world. Pigs and boars came to have a religious significance among the Celts and they were assigned to aristocrats as part of their grave goods.

Pigs were included in the mythology and are found on Celtic helmets, found in art and the boar became one of the royal symbols among the early Irish kings.

Horses and dogs were bred for both hunting and warfare. There seems no trace of the use of donkeys and mules before contact with the Italian peninsula. Chickens and cats were also found in Celtic farmsteads. Caesar says of the British Celts: "Hares, fowl, and geese they think it unlawful to eat, but rear them for pleasure and amusement."

One of the interesting things in Ireland is the survival of ancient boundary pillar stones, used to delineate farm boundaries. One writer says they were first erected by Gaulish Celts when they arrived in Ireland. True or not, the Brehon laws have some stringent rules about farmers and their duty to the land and community.

The picture that archaeology reveals of a stable Celtic farming economy is certainly a different one from the popular notion of itinerant war bands.

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LECTURE 73

CELTIC SOCIETY  
PART II

WOMEN IN CELTIC SOCIETY:

Celtic women were the subject of much comment from the writers of Greece and Rome, and there continues to be much speculation and argument about them.

Compared with their sisters in the classical world, they enjoyed considerable rights and freedom and, indeed, even political power.

The classical writers are eager to point out that Celtic women are not as "womanly" as the Greeks and Romans. One writer comments:

"A whole group of foreigners would not be able to withstand a single Celt if he called his wife to his assistance. The wife is even more formidable, She is usually very strong, and has blue eyes; in rage her neck veins swell, she gnashes her teeth, and brandishes her snow-white robust arms. She begins to strike blows mingled with kicks, as if they were so many missiles sent from the string of a catapult.

The voices of these women are formidable and threatening, even when they are not angry but being friendly. But all Celtic women, with equal care, keep neat And clean and in some areas, such as among the Aquitani, no woman can be seen, be she never so poor, in soiled or ragged clothing."

Our classical sources are not interested in recording any details about Celtic female leaders unless they are exceptional, such as Cartimandua or Boudicca.  
*Car ti man du a*

There are several women leaders mentioned in the classical writings, such as <sup>O no mar is</sup> Onomaris, which means "mountain Ash" who was chieftainess of the <sup>Scor dis ci</sup> Scordisci. She is recorded as leading <sup>Il ly ri ans</sup> her people in battle against the Illyrians of the Balkans.

The Scordisci settled by the Danube and founded their capital at <sup>Sin ig dū nam</sup> Sinigdunum, which is now Belgrade.

○ QUEEN TEUTA' in the year 231 BC, a group of tribes in the region of modern Kotor on the Illyrian coast were ruled by a king named Agron. When he died of Pleurisy in the fall he was succeeded by a woman called Teuta, meaning the "peoples Queen"

Polybius, a Greek writer, has little good to say about Teuta. Mainly because she decided to extend her kingdom by attacking the neighboring Greek state of Epiros.

The kingdom of Epiros was employing Celtic mercenaries at the time, who decided to join forces with their compatriots from Teuta's kingdom. Polybius is very sarcastic about Epiros decesion to trust the mercenaries.

When Rome decided to take a hand in Teuta's affairs, they sent ambassadors to lecture her. Roman arrogance caused Teuta to give way to a fit of womanish petulance. She had the Roman ambassadors assassinated, but not till they were already on thier ships ready to sail, because of the rules of hospitality.

This was her unwise decesion, as Rome sent 200 ships to attack Teuta's kingdom. They were beseiged by legions who systematically reduced the rest of her cities. Teuta finally concluded a treaty with Rome, agreed to pay reparations and gave assurances of her good behaviour in the future. Rome victory was celebrated in 228 BC.

<sup>chí ố mã rồ</sup> <sup>or tá gôn</sup> **CHIOMARA**, wife of Ortagion -Chiomara was captured by the Romans in 189 BC. A Centurion raped her, and when he discovered she was the wife of the Celtic king they were fighting against, Greed overcame caution, and he sent a ransom note to Ortagion.

The exchange took place on a river bank in neutral territory. While the centurian was busy picking up his gold,

Chiomara turned, took a sword from those who had come to escort her to her husband, and calmly decapitated him.

She then took his head, in good Celtic style, to her husband. The greetings exchanged as given by Plutarch is fascinating.

"woman, a fine thing, (is) good faith."

"a better thing, only one man alive who had intercourse with me."

It is believed this preserves a genuine gnomic Celtic idiom.[]

BOUDICCA [] [] [] [] [] Dominating all the women of the ancient Celtic world, and already mentioned is Boudicca, or Boadicea as it is Latinized. She deserves mention again here. When her husband, king prasutagus died in 60 or 61 AD leaving Boudicca a widow, Neros policy was one of direct rule.

Prasutagus, in Roman fashion, had made a will leaving his kingdom and goods to be divided between the Roman emperor and his two daughters "in equal shares".

The fact that Boudicca was subsequently accepted as ruler of the Iceni meant that she had to have a bloodline claim in her own right as well as being elected by her family to that position in accordance with Celtic law.

Rome betrayed their trust when Catus Decianus marched with some of his troops where the Iceni greeted them with the usual Celtic hospitality. Decianus turned his troops on the people, seizing goods and leading away citizens as hostages and slaves.

Boudicca protested so she was stripped and whipped in public while her two teenage daughters were raped in front of her. Others of her relations were taken into custody

Boudicca now emerges as absolute ruler and war leader of the Iceni. "This is not the first time that Britons have been led to battle by a woman" records Tacitus. Other tribes came flocking to her banner. Boudicca proved to be a military strategist of exceptional merit.

She managed to ambush the IX Hispania-some 6000 legionaries and 500 cavalry, even tho they had won many battles against the Celts. Boudicca annihilated this elite force except for the 500 cavalry, who managed to escape

She proceeded to take and burn 3 more towns, including London leaving only the army of the Roman governor and a couple of legions. However, it was enough for Suetonius was able to defeat Boudicca northwest of St. Albans.

Little is known of Boudicca and her daughters after this. She did not fall into Roman hands. Tacitus believes she escaped the battlefield and then took poison rather than fall into Roman hands.

Dio Cassius says she simply fell sick and died, and adds that the Britons gave her a rich burial. He also says she was a priestess of Andrasta, goddess of battle and victory.

Another important woman warrior and leader is <sup>Maeve</sup> Medb of Connacht or <sup>Book of Munster</sup> Queen Maeve of Ireland. But lets watch a film about her. <sup>film 27min</sup>  
try to start by 15-20 after

WOMEN AND THE LAW - In the classical sources there are references to women as priestesses and prophetesses. <sup>Caesar</sup> ~~he~~ also says such women were married but very independent of their husbands.

We know something of the role of women in insular Celtic society in as much as their legal position is clearly marked out in the BREHON LAWS . whose first recorded codification was in 438 AD, and the laws of Hywel Dda of Wales from the 9th century AD. <sup>hū wēl dā</sup>

What we know before the Christian era of Celtic law is based on the rather biased writings of Julius Caesar. However, he does seem to be echoing the Celtic concept of female property rights when he says of the Gaulish Celts.

" When a Gaul marries, he adds to the dowry that his wife



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brings with her a portion of his own property estimated to be of equal value. A joint account is kept of the whole amount, and the profits which it earns are put aside; and when either dies, the survivor receives both shares together with accumulated profits."

So, unlike their Greek and Roman sisters, Celtic women could inherit property.

However, Caesar goes overboard when he says:

"Wives are shared between groups of ten or twelve men, especially between brothers and between fathers and sons; but the offspring of these unions are counted as the children of the man with whom a particular woman cohabited first.

This is a total misrepresentation of the polygamous society of the early Celts but the Romans seemed preoccupied with the "liberated" attitude of the early Celts.

when criticized by the Emperess Julia Augusta early in the 3rd century AD for lacking morals a Celtic woman responded: "We Celtic women obey the demands of Nature in a more moral way than the women of Rome. We consort openly with the best men but you, of Rome, allow yourselves to be debauched in secret by the vilest"

It's not recorded how the empress reacted.

In both surviving codifications of Celtic Law systems, women certainly enjoyed considerable rights. A girl under the age of seven years of any social class in the Irish system had the same honour prices as a cleric. From seven girls were sent to be educated, just as boys were.

They completed their education at the age of fourteen while boys continued to seventeen. However, the *Bretha* *Brēthā* *Krēthā* *Croilge* allowed the girl to continue until the age of seventeen "if required."

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Women could inherit property and remained the owner of all property brought into a marriage. they fought alongside Men until Christianity abolished the practice with the introduction of the Lex Innocentium at the synod of Birr in 697 AD.

In Irish and Welsh law there were nine types of marriage, which corresponded to the eight types found in Hindu law of Manu dating from the 1st century BC.

10/ Hindu law closely parallels Celtic law, and many of the same principles can be found in the Irish and Hindu texts.

Divorce was permitted for a variety of reasons, and men and women had equal rights to divorce each other. One reason a woman could divorce in Irish law was if her husband snored.

In Welsh law, if a wife found her husband committing adultery, she was exempt from any legal punishment if, in a fit of jealousy, she attacked him, his mistress or even members of their families.

The exemption was limited to a period of three days from the time of learning of her husband's affair. By that time, so the Welsh law-givers reasoned, the woman would have recovered from any shock which might cause such "irrational acts". After that, the matter was deemed to be cold-blooded vengeance.

In both law systems women were protected from rape and, indeed, from sexual harassment. In Ireland, the laws are clear that physical or even verbal harassment was punishable by a whole series of fines.

□ Women have played a prominent part in Celtic life, from the mother goddess and the pantheon of female deities down to a whole range of powerful historical female leaders, priestesses and Christian saints. Their role did not stop with the coming of Christianity but continued into medieval times among the insular Celts.

○ A unique piece of "feminist" literature emerges from

12th century Ireland in the form of the BANSHENCHAS, a book on the genealogies of leading women. In fact, this could be claimed as the first European book about women in their own right.